makeup of the National Conference's leadership. By December 1948, Whitehall developed the view that Abdullah's involvement with local Indian communists and his constant contacts with the Soviets explained the steadily rising communist influence in Kashmir.

From the initiation of his premiership on 5 March 1948, Abdullah embarked upon a systematic campaign to publicly humiliate and vilify the Maharaja. The state seemed to be like a driverless truck that was propelled by its own momentum. Abdullah had a single-point agenda and that was the Maharaja's removal. There was a total deadlock in the state between the Maharaja and Abdullah's government and in this highly tense atmosphere, Sardar Patel invited the Maharaja, his wife and son to New Delhi, in April 1949.[4] On 29 April 1949, Sardar Patel told the Maharaja that while Abdullah was pressing for his abdication, Patel felt it would be good if the Maharaja and the Maharani left the state for a few months. Patel argued that this was in the national interest, in view of the complications arising from the UN-sponsored plebiscite proposals. In the interim, Patel proposed that Yuvaraja Karan Singh should be appointed the Regent to carry out the Maharaja's duties and responsibilities in his absence. The die was cast. The Government of India stepped in to depose yet another Maharaja in its long history of interference in the administration of the state. The Maharaja never returned to his state and stayed in New Delhi *en route* to his new home in Bombay. From New Delhi, he issued a proclamation, on 20 June 1949, appointing Yuvaraja Karan Singh as the Regent.[5]